Opposites Attract, but Do They Last? The Role of Cultural Dissimilarities in Relationship Endurance

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Abstract

How does cultural dissimilarities among spouses a ect relationship Endurance? While extensive research has examined the determinants of relationship formation, far less attention has been given to the factors that sustain relationships over time. In particular, the role of cultural di erences between spouses remains under-explored. This study investigates the impact of ancestral diversity on relationship stability, advancing the hypothesis that moderate cultural distance between partners fosters Endurance. At the core of this dynamic are two opposing forces: exploration and synergy on one hand, and misalignment and frictions on the other. While cultural diversity introduces novelty and enriches relationships through intellectual and behavioral synergy, excessive di erences can lead to discord, communication barriers, and relational strain. Leveraging the rich ancestral diversity of the modern U.S. population, we provide empirical evidence that a balanced fusion of backgrounds enhances relationship stability, primarily through its e ects on joy of discovering the unknown and hurdles in e ective communication.

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Table III: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Below 35 Years Old

	Separation Rate		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Cultural distance	−0.30***	−0.29***	−0.26***
	(0.096)	(0.095)	(0.089)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.73**	0.61**	0.56*
	(0.32)	(0.28)	(0.28)
Ancestry FE	✓	✓	✓
Ancestral Continent Pair FE	✓	✓	✓
Age Pair FE		✓	✓
Education Pair FE			✓
Observations	2,811	2,811	2,811
Ancestry pairs	401	401	401
R^2	0.17	0.23	0.24
Optimal cultural distance	.203	.234	.232
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.033	.051	.072
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-50%	-55%	-50%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-71%	-64%	-60%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

Table IV: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Up to 35 Years Old

	Separation Rate		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Cultural distance	-0.32***	-0.32***	-0.31***
	(0.087)	(0.076)	(0.069)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.73**	0.67***	0.67***
	(0.28)	(0.24)	(0.23)
Ancestry FE	✓	✓	✓
Ancestral Continent Pair FE	✓	✓	✓
Age Pair FE		✓	✓
Education Pair FE			✓
Observations	3,186	3,186	3,186
Ancestry pairs	452	452	452
R^2	0.16	0.23	0.23
Optimal cultural distance	.219	.235	.23
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.022	.022	.018
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-56%	-59%	-57%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-70%	-67%	-67%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

Table V: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Below 40 Years Old

	Separation Rate		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Cultural distance	−0.28***	−0.32***	−0.32***
	(0.068)	(0.062)	(0.061)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.49**	0.52***	0.54***
	(0.22)	(0.19)	(0.19)
Ancestry FE	✓	✓	✓
Ancestral Continent Pair FE	✓	✓	✓
Age Pair FE		✓	✓
Education Pair FE			✓
Observations	4,524	4,524	4,524
Ancestry pairs	610	610	610
R^2	0.16	0.23	0.23
Optimal cultural distance	.289	.302	.291
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.094	.064	.055
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-68%	-78%	-75%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-57%	-63%	-64%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

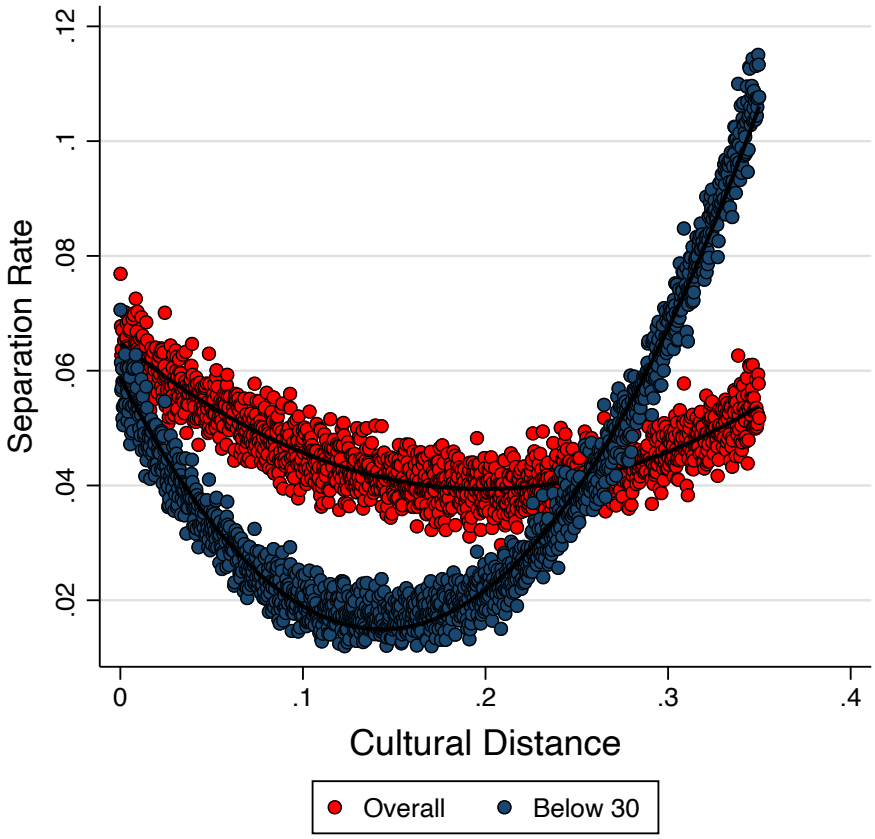

Figure 2: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance

Notes: This figure illustrates the impact of cultural distance on the probability of a relationship breakup within a year, across the full range of cultural variation observed in the data.

5 Concluding Remarks

This study sheds light on a fundamental but underexplored aspect of relationship dynamics: the role of ancestral cultural diversity in shaping the endurance of romantic partnerships. By combining a theoretical framework with rich empirical evidence from the diverse landscape of U.S.-born couples, we demonstrate that cultural dissimilarity exerts a non-linear effect on relationship stability. Specifically, we find that relationship endurance is maximized at an intermediate level of cultural distance—where the benefits of novelty and complementarity are harnessed without incurring the full costs of misalignment and communication barriers.

Our findings underscore the importance of balance in cultural differences. While too much similarity may lead to stagnation and lack of dynamism, excessive divergence can breed discord and misunderstanding. The optimal zone lies in between—where cultural

contrast sparks discovery and synergy, but not at the expense of shared understanding and cohesion.

In highlighting the dual forces of spark and cohesion, this research invites a broader appreciation for the nuanced ways in which diversity operates within intimate relationships. Our findings suggest that while diversity can enrich and invigorate human connections, its positive effects are contingent upon a threshold beyond which it may begin to unravel the very ties it once strengthened.

References

Lind, J. T. and H. Mehlum (2010): "With or without U? The appropriate test for a U-shaped relationship," *Oxford bulletin of economics and statistics*, 72, 109–118.

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A Robustness Checks and Sensitivity Analyses

A.1 Including branches with US

Table A.1: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance

	Separation Rate		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Cultural distance	0.020	0.032	0.042
	(0.049)	(0.048)	(0.047)
Cultural distance (squared)	−0.092	−0.14	−0.16
	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.15)
Ancestry FE	✓	✓	✓
Ancestral Continent Pair FE	✓	✓	✓
Age Pair FE		✓	✓
Education Pair FE			✓
Observations	836,423	836,423	836,423
Ancestry pairs	2353	2353	2353
R^2	0.047	0.066	0.067
Optimal cultural distance	.108	.116	.127
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.342	.249	.188
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	3%	5%	6%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	44%	77%	90%

Notes: This table establishes that the results are unaffected qualitatively if we allow the sample to include couples that have at least a partner with both parents being born in the US. All specifications include fixed-effects for year of survey as well as each partner's parental birthplaces. Multi-way standard errors (clustered at the partner's 1 maternal birthplace level, partner's 1 paternal birthplace level, partner's 2 maternal birthplace level, and partner's 2 paternal birthplace level) are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

A.2 African and Native Americans

Table A.2: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance

	Separation Rate			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Cultural distance	−0.27***	−0.31***	−0.24***	−0.24***
	(0.038)	(0.058)	(0.045)	(0.056)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.53***	0.64***	0.48***	0.48**
	(0.10)	(0.16)	(0.15)	(0.19)
African Americans		✗		✗
Native Americans			✗	✗
Observations	68,750	22,091	64,275	17,900
Ancestry pairs	2143	2007	2062	1904
R^2	0.11	0.20	0.11	0.21
Optimal cultural distance	.251	.240	.245	.256
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.001	.001	.014	.039
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-55%	-56%	-48%	-47%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-64%	-62%	-59%	-48%

Notes: This table establishes that the results are unaffected qualitatively if we allow the sample to include couples that have at least a partner with both parents being born in the US. All specifications include fixed-effects for year of survey as well as each partner's parental birthplaces. Multi-way standard errors (clustered at the partner's 1 maternal birthplace level, partner's 1 paternal birthplace level, partner's 2 maternal birthplace level, and partner's 2 paternal birthplace level) are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

A.3 Horse-Race with Genetic Distance

Table A.3: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Horse-Race with Genetic Distance

	Separation Rate		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Cultural distance	−0.26***		−0.27***
	(0.068)		(0.10)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.52**		0.56**
	(0.20)		(0.24)
Genetic distance		−0.15**	0.030
		(0.076)	(0.12)
Genetic distance (squared)		0.26	−0.086
		(0.22)	(0.27)
Observations	21,241	21,241	21,241
Ancestry pairs	1857	1857	1857
R^2	0.20	0.20	0.20
Cultural distance:			
Optimal distance	.246		.244
Statistical significance (p-value ≤)	.030		.032
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-48%		-50%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-52%		-56%
Genetic distance:			
Optimal distance		.291	.171
Statistical significance (p-value ≤)		.175	.405
Effect size ($Fst_{min} \rightarrow Fst^*$)		-34%	4%
Effect size ($Fst_{max} \rightarrow Fst^*$)		-44%	45%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

A.4 Estimates by Educational Attainment

Table A.4: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Estimates by Educational Attainment

	Separation Rate			
	HS Completed		College Graduates	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Cultural distance	−0.29***	−0.33***	−0.31**	−0.22
	(0.11)	(0.12)	(0.14)	(0.14)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.63**	0.73**	0.86*	0.57
	(0.32)	(0.36)	(0.45)	(0.38)
Ancestry FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Ancestral Continent Pair FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Age Pair FE		✓		✓
Observations	14,016	14,016	3,142	3,142
Ancestry pairs	1150	1150	737	737
R^2	0.16	0.23	0.29	0.43
Optimal cultural distance	.229	.224	.180	.195
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.054	.050	.043	.089
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-46%	-51%	-59%	-48%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-57%	-64%	-82%	-69%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

A.5 Local Analysis

Table A.5: Couple's Cultural Distance and Relationship Endurance: Local Analysis

	Separation Rate			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Cultural distance	−0.31***	−0.32***	−0.31***	−0.27***
	(0.058)	(0.059)	(0.058)	(0.090)
Cultural distance (squared)	0.64***	0.65***	0.64***	0.54**
	(0.16)	(0.17)	(0.16)	(0.25)
Region FE		✓		
State FE			✓	
Micro area FE				✓
Observations	22,091	22,091	22,091	10,304
Ancestry pairs	2007	2007	2007	1324
R^2	0.20	0.20	0.20	0.28
Optimal cultural distance	.240	.243	.243	.248
Statistical significance (p-value $\leq$)	.002	.002	.002	.053
Effect size ($\psi_{min} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-56%	-57%	-57%	-52%
Effect size ($\psi_{max} \rightarrow \psi^*$)	-62%	-63%	-63%	-56%

Notes: This table establishes that there exists an intermediate level of cultural distance between partners that minimizes their risk of breaking up within a year. All specifications include fixed effects for the year of the survey, each partner's ancestry (separately for partner 1 and partner 2), and the combination of their ancestral continents (i.e., the continent-pair of their ancestries). Multi-way clustered standard errors—at partner 1's maternal and paternal birthplace levels and partner 2's maternal and paternal birthplace levels—are reported in parentheses. *** Significant at the 1 percent level.

A.6 Religion

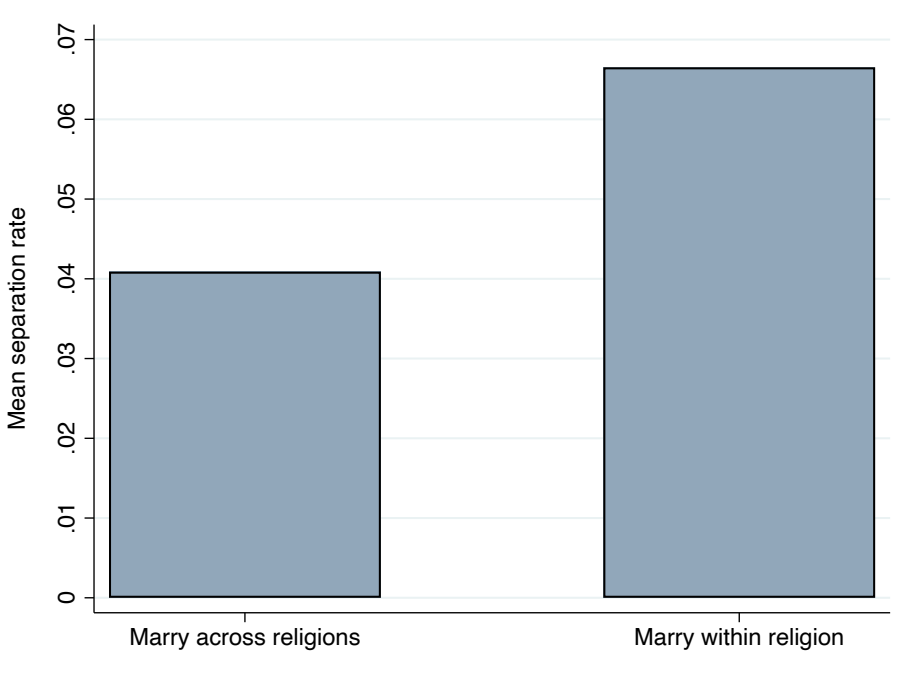


Figure A.1: Couple's Religion and Relationship Endurance

Notes: This figure illustrates the mean divorce probability according to whether there is religious homogeneity across partners.

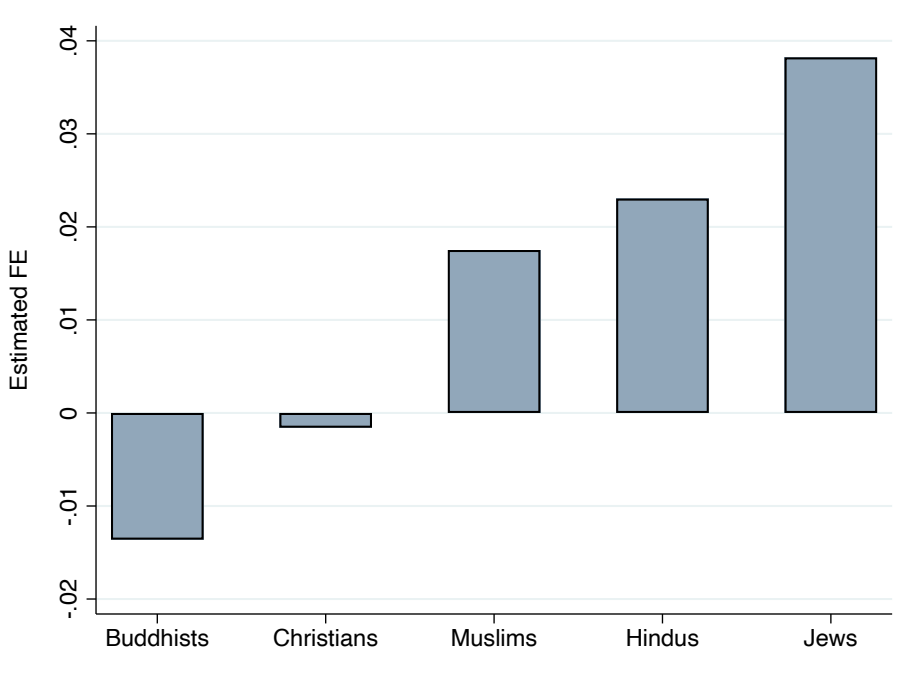
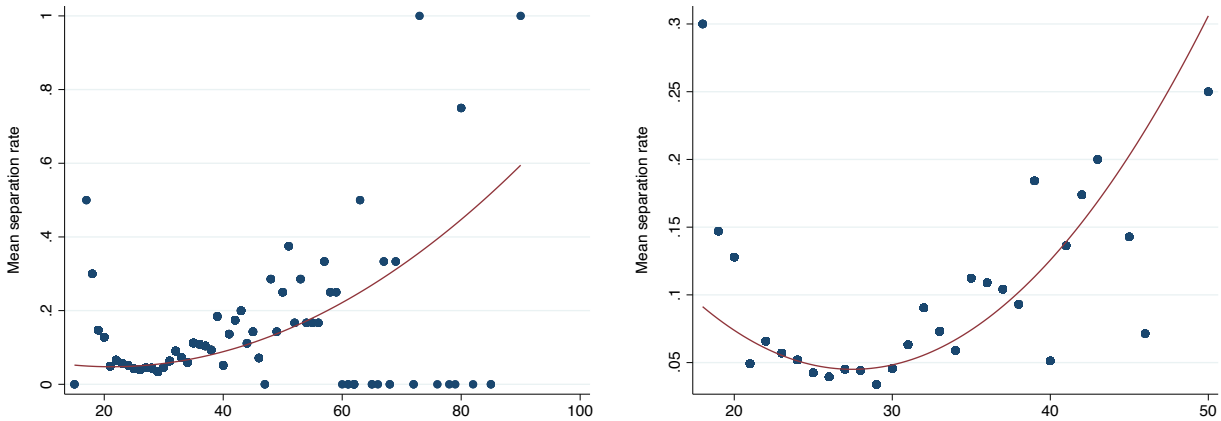


Figure A.2: Christian as Focal Point

Notes: This figure illustrates the estimated religion score for five combinations where the focal point is Christian.

A.7 Age

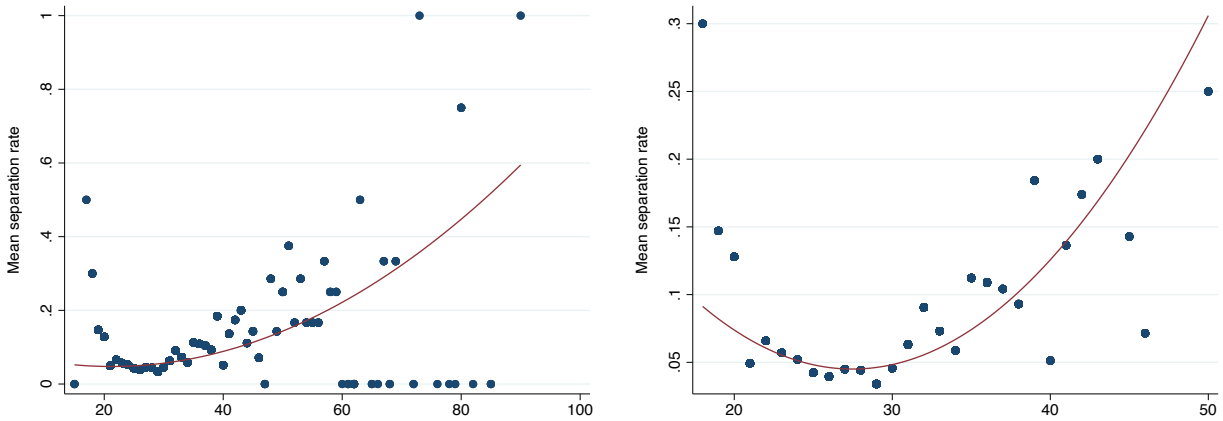


(a) No observation threshold

(b) Threshold of 10 observations

Figure A.3: Couple's Age and Relationship Endurance: 25 Yrs Old as Focal Point

Notes: This figure illustrates the mean divorce probability for permutations where focal point is an individual who is 25 years old.

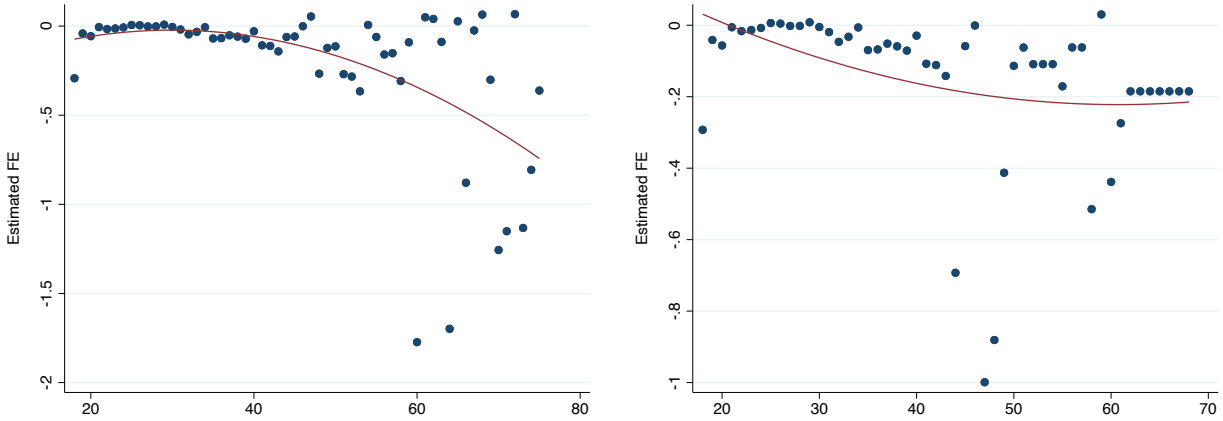


(a) No observation threshold

(b) Threshold of 10 observations

Figure A.4: Couple's Age and Relationship Endurance: 35 Yrs Old as Focal Point

Notes: This figure illustrates the mean divorce probability for permutations where focal point is an individual who is 35 years old.

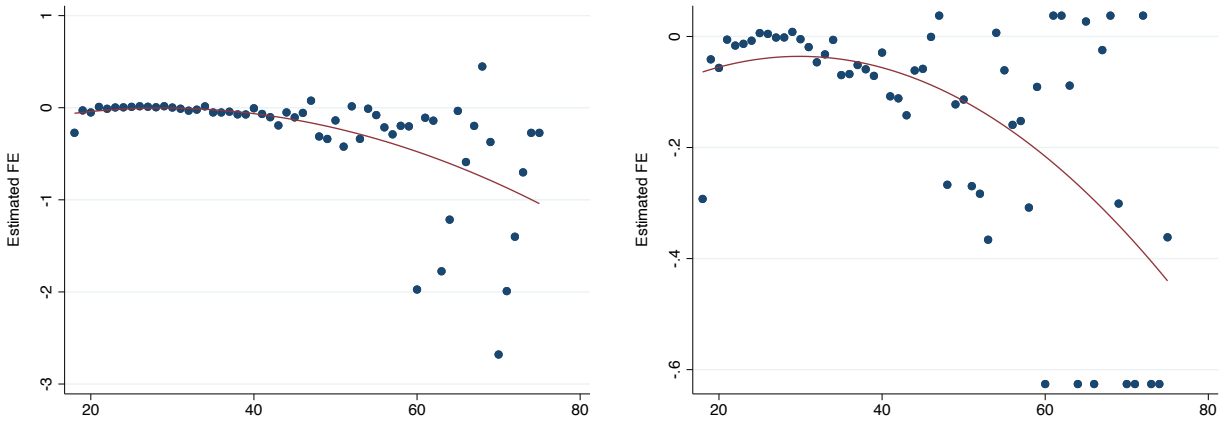


(a) No observation threshold

(b) Threshold of 10 observations

Figure A.5: Couple's Age and Relationship Endurance: Age Score for 25 Yrs Old as Focal Point

Notes: This figure illustrates the estimated age score for permutations where focal point is an individual who is 25 years old.



(a) Accounting for cohorts

(b) Winsorizing score

Figure A.6: Couple's Age and Relationship Endurance: Age Score for 25 Yrs Old as Focal Point

Notes: This figure illustrates the estimated age score for permutations where focal point is an individual who is 25 years old.